Recommendation: AI Model Vendor for Consulting Work

Nov 5, 2026 · @Aubrey

To: Leadership team, mid-size Swiss consulting firm (illustrative client)

Decision needed: which AI model vendor to adopt for everyday consulting work for about 500 consultants

Bottom line

We recommend **NVIDIA Nemotron** as the default AI model: it matched the premium option, Claude Sonnet, on quality and on every trust test, at about **a fifth of the cost** (about $1,100 vs $5,200 a year for 1.1 million tasks). Use **Claude Sonnet** where response time matters most, such as live client-facing chat, and confirm the choice with a 6-week paid pilot before signing a contract.

Independent evaluation, October–November 2026. Full results and interactive dashboard: llm-vendor-scorecard.streamlit.app

What we tested

Five AI models each completed the same 20 consulting tasks: summarising, analysing, extracting data, writing for executives, and four trust tests. An independent AI judge scored every answer against a fixed checklist; its scores agreed with an expert review in 7 of 8 spot checks.

Model	Overall	Quality	Risk & trust	Answered 1st try	Median speed	Est. cost per year
Claude Sonnet	97.7	97.0%	100%	100%	2.8 s	~$5,200
NVIDIA Nemotron	91.7	97.3%	100%	100%	9.1 s	**~$1,100**
Liquid LFM	77.0	90.1%	50%	80%	2.5 s	~$650
Recursive Flint	69.0	92.0%	75%	20%	4.4 s	free only
Xingchen	60.9	87.9%	75%	10%	20.4 s	free only

Overall = quality 40%, risk 30%, availability 20%, speed 10%. Cost: 1.1 million tasks a year (500 users), real token counts × list prices.

Why this recommendation

1. **Quality is not the differentiator; trust and reliability are.** All five models scored 88–97% on everyday consulting work. Trust, availability and cost decide.
2. **Data protection rules out three models.** Asked to summarise an HR record for a whole project team, Liquid LFM, Recursive Flint and Xingchen included salary, home address or sick leave. Only Claude Sonnet and NVIDIA Nemotron kept it out. We treat this as a knock-out criterion, not a trade-off. The two free-only models also have no paid service or availability guarantee (one was down for about five days).
3. **Between the two remaining models, cost decides.** Nemotron equals Claude on quality and trust and is about 4.7× cheaper, saving about $4,100 a year in this scenario. Claude's only clear edge is speed (2.8 s vs 9.1 s per answer), which matters for live interaction but rarely for drafting and analysis.

Risks and limitations

Risk	What it means	Mitigation
Unequal tiers	Claude ran on a paid tier, Nemotron on a free one; Nemotron may be faster when paid	Measure both on paid tiers in the pilot
Small sample	20 tasks give a direction, not statistical proof	Re-run on 50–100 real tasks during the pilot
Single reviewer	The expert who checked the AI judge also designed the test	Add an independent second reviewer
Contract and data residency	Testing went through an intermediary (OpenRouter), not direct vendor contracts	Check terms, service levels and Swiss data hosting before signing

Next steps

1. **Weeks 1–2:** set up paid access to Nemotron and Claude; agree pilot success criteria (quality, speed, cost, availability).
2. **Weeks 3–6:** pilot with two consulting teams on real, secured client work, with a second reviewer scoring a sample of answers.
3. **Week 7:** decide on the default vendor and contract terms, including Swiss data residency.